

Operator & Tool Crib

The people at the machine making parts, and the people who keep them fed
— where every upstream decision becomes a green light or a red flag.

PRODUCTION

“ Green means go. Anything else means stop and fix something before the first chip flies.

WHO THEY ARE

The Operator (machinist) checks the schedule, verifies readiness, runs setup, gets the first article inspected and certified, then runs production while doing in-process checks and keeping the time clock honest. The Tool Crib — a dedicated role in larger shops, absorbed by the operator in smaller ones — assembles cutting tools, material, and fixtures onto a cart and delivers it machine-side so the operator can start clean.

Everything upstream — estimating, planning, programming, purchasing — either shows up as green on the work order, or as a red flag the operator has to escalate before running a single part.

A DAY IN THE LIFE

Kit	Tool Crib pulls cutting tools per WO sequence, kits a cart (tools + material + fixtures), and delivers it to the bay.
Check	Operator walks up, checks the machine schedule top-down for the next WO, looking for green cues.
Verify	Confirms readiness: material at the machine, tools kitted, pre-plan checklist all green in the operator section.
Setup	Starts the setup clock (60-min target), runs the first part, does the First Article Inspection , certifies to run.
Run	Switches to running mode — cycle-time clock on, in-process checks per piece, deburr, coolant, chips.
Close	Enters quantity completed & queued to next op, prints traceability labels, checks off teardown.

SNAPSHOT

Workflow stage	Production
Setup target	~60 minutes
Time tracking	Manual play / pause
Gate to run	First Article + green
Tooling cost	\$100+ per endmill

ENVIRONMENT & TECH COMFORT

This is the shop-floor persona. Operator is standing at a machine, often in gloves, hands dirty, glancing at a shared terminal between cutting cycles — not seated at a clean desk. Glance-ability, large touch targets, and minimal typing matter enormously. Software comfort varies widely by individual and shift.

Software proficiency	Mixed
Manufacturing depth	Very high
Time free to interact with UI	Low

IN THEIR WORDS

“For us machinists, we see green — that’s the whole language. If the work order’s green, I can run it. If it’s not, I’m not touching the machine.”

WHAT DRIVES THEM — AND WHAT GETS IN THE WAY

The lens Product & Design should hold when building for this user: what they're trying to achieve, where the current experience fails them, and what they need from the product to succeed.

● GOALS

- Hit setup and cycle-time targets, feeding accurate actuals back into costing.
- Never crash the machine — right speeds & feeds, work-holding, and program.
- Protect tool life — faster isn't cheaper when endmills cost \$100+ each.
- Get the first article approved fast so the machine runs instead of sitting idle.

● FRUSTRATIONS

- Time tracking is manual — easy to forget play/pause at lunch or a break.
- The machine sits idle waiting for QA buyoff of the first article.
- Tool wear history isn't shown per-tool — it's judged by feel and jagged edges.
- The color system takes training — you must know which role owns each section.

● NEEDS FROM PROSHOP

- A glance-able, glove-friendly WO view — big status, minimal typing.
- Frictionless (or automatic) time tracking so actuals stay honest.
- A self-inspect path so the machine doesn't idle waiting for QA.
- Per-tool wear signals so tool changes aren't a guess.

THE NUMBERS THEY'RE MEASURED ON

Setup time

Actual vs. target — auto-updates the target for the next run.

Runtime

Cycle time per part (min / pc).

Tool life

Parts-per-endmill vs. target — speed traded against wear.

Scrap

Scrap and rework rate; zero safety incidents.

PROSHOP MODULES THEY LIVE IN

Shop Floor & Scheduling **HOME**

Visual Work Instructions **HOME**

Tool & Fixture Management **HOME**

Quality Systems & Inspection **READS**

Job Costing & Financial Data **FEEDS**

WHERE THEY SIT IN THE FLOW

UPSTREAM

Buyer & Planner

Deliver material + the finalized, green WO

READY WO



THIS PERSONA

Operator & Tool Crib

Sets up, cuts, inspects & queues to next op

FINISHED



DOWNSTREAM

QA / Inspection

Final-inspects the finished parts

This is where all the upstream discipline becomes real cost: crash a machine, scrap a first article, or set up on the wrong revision and the shop pays for hours it can't bill. The manual play/pause clock is also the feedback loop into costing — a forgotten pause quietly corrupts the next estimator's targets.